

LIFE-STUDY OF EPHESIANS

MESSAGE THIRTY-NINE

THE BELIEVER'S STANDARD

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Our mind needs to be purged from the natural concept that uplifts the apostles above the ordinary believers in Christ. Apostles are simply those sent by God to carry out His purpose for the building of the church. Certainly we all can be such sent ones, and, having been sent, we all can speak for God as His prophets, His spokesmen. Do not be held back by traditional teachings. Instead, believe the fact that the stewardship of the grace of God has been given to every believer.

THE REVELATION OF THE MYSTERY

In 3:3 Paul says that by revelation the mystery was made known to him. Do you think that the mystery has been made known only to the Apostle Paul and not been made known to all the other New Testament believers? We all have received the revelation of the mystery, the very revelation given to Paul. The reason Paul wrote the book of Ephesians was so that all the saints might know the mystery of Christ. In the years the Lord's recovery has been in this country, the saints have seen more and more of the mystery of Christ. By receiving this revelation, we are constituted apostles and prophets, and we are qualified to speak concerning Christ and the church.

As prophets, we need to speak to those around us, regardless of whether we think that they understand what we are saying. Our responsibility is to speak wherever we are - at home or at our places of employment. Those who are parents need to speak to their children concerning God's economy. We also should contact our parents and relatives and tell them what we have seen regarding God's eternal purpose. Do not be concerned about what others may think of you. Speak so that the unbelievers may be brought to the Lord. If we do not speak, how can others be saved? If we speak, at least some of those who hear us will come to the Lord. What an impact there will be if all the saints in the Lord's recovery open their mouths and speak concerning Christ and the church! Many of us have been cheated by the enemy into thinking that we are not qualified to speak for the Lord. Do not expect brothers with certain outstanding gifts to do all the speaking. This concept is wrong. As those who have received grace and who have seen the revelation of the mystery of Christ, we are today's apostles and prophets, and we can speak for the Lord.

ALL SERVING ONES

In 3:7 Paul said, “Of which I became a minister according to the gift of the grace of God, which was given to me according to the operation of His power.” The Greek word translated “minister” in this verse is the same word that is elsewhere in the New Testament rendered “deacon.” In fact “deacon” is the anglicized form of the Greek word used here. A minister or deacon is a serving one, not a high official. In this verse Paul was saying that he became a servant. According to the natural concept, the ministers are above the elders, and the elders are above the deacons. But if we have the proper understanding of this verse, we shall see that the ministers actually are deacons, those who serve. The word “minister” is a good word, but its meaning has been spoiled by traditional usage. According to the New Testament, to say that one is a minister is to say that he is simply a serving one. All believers in Christ are serving ones.

THE OPERATION OF GOD’S POWER

In 3:7 Paul speaks of the operation of God’s power. This is the power of the resurrection life (Phil. 3:10), which operates within the apostle and all the believers (Eph. 1:19; 3:20). By such an inward operating power of life, the gift of grace was given to the apostle; that is, it was manifested in him.

The Greek word rendered “operation” in verse 7 is the word from which the English word “energy” is derived. Within us and among us there is a divine energizing. This operation, this energizing, was not exclusively for the Apostle Paul; it is for all the saints. This is proved by 4:16, which, using the same Greek word, speaks of the “operation in measure of each one part.” The very same energizing that was in Paul is in every part of the Body. Such an energy is working within us today.

THE DISPENSATION OF THE MYSTERY

In 3:9 Paul speaks of bringing to light what is the dispensation of the mystery. The word “dispensation” here refers to the process of dispensing Christ as life, as the life supply, and as everything to the believers. We all have a part in such a marvelous dispensation. As believers we need to be brought up to God’s standard, the standard set by the Apostle Paul.

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MESSAGE FORTY

THE WAY TO REACH THE STANDARD

In the last message we saw the believer's standard. In this message we shall consider the way to reach this standard.

Ephesians 3:1 says, "For this cause I Paul, the prisoner of Christ Jesus on behalf of you, the nations." This verse is not a complete sentence; it contains a subject but not a predicate. All the verses from 3:2 through 3:21 are a parenthesis, and Darby places them within parentheses in his translation. This means that 4:1 continues Paul's thought in 3:1. As Paul was writing this Epistle, a burden rose up in him in 3:2 to utter a parenthetical word. Then he continued in 4:1, "I beseech you therefore, I, the prisoner in the Lord, to walk worthily of the calling with which you were called." Here Paul completed the thought he began to express in 3:1. Thus, by putting 3:1 and 4:1 together we have a complete thought.

The lengthy parenthesis between 3:1 and 4:1 is an extremely crucial section of Ephesians. In this portion Paul indicated that he longed for all the believers to be the same as he was. As those who would walk worthily of God's calling, we must take Paul as our standard. In order that we might do this, Paul presented himself as an example. In chapter three Paul did not speak on the basis of being an apostle called by God, but he spoke on the basis of being a prisoner of the Lord. As such a prisoner, he was the standard model of one who walked worthily of God's calling. In chapter three of Ephesians Paul presented not only the standard, but also the way to reach this standard. Let us consider the various aspects of this way in some detail.

THE UNIVERSAL STEWARDSHIP

Firstly, we must all be stewards, just as Paul was (3:2). The stewardship is not limited to the leading apostles. Rather, it is universal; that is, it is for all the Lord's disciples. For example, the parable of the steward in Luke 16 was spoken to the disciples. This indicates that every believer, including all of us, must be a steward. I believe that, when Paul spoke of the stewardship in 3:2, he realized within him that the stewardship is for all believers.

In Ephesians 3 Paul develops a concept presented by the Lord Jesus in the four Gospels. The Gospels reveal that all the believers are both stewards and slaves (Matt. 25:14-30). According to the Gospels, a slave is not different from a servant, a steward. The concept in Ephesians 3 is that not only the apostles are stewards and servants, but that all the believers are stewards and servants.

Because of the influence of their religious background and environment, not many Christians regard themselves as stewards. Do you realize that you are not simply a believer, one who trusts in the Lord for salvation? Moreover, have you seen that you are not just a

disciple, one who is disciplined and trained? Have you seen that you are a steward, one who serves others with the riches of Christ? We all need to regard ourselves as stewards. If we have this concept, our whole Christian life will be changed. We are all stewards; even we could be called waiters, those imparting Christ's riches to others as nourishing food. The "kitchen" in which all this food is prepared is the church. If you do not have anything with which to serve others, you may come to this "kitchen" and receive the supply.

RECEIVING GRACE

Because our stewardship is the stewardship of the grace of God, we need to receive grace, even the abundance of grace. Yes, we all can be God's sent ones and God's spokesmen, but in order to fulfill such a function, we must have grace. John 1:16 says, "For of His fullness we all received, and grace upon grace."

We have pointed out that all the believers are stewards. Furthermore, we as the stewards have the supply that comes from an excellent "kitchen." But when we contact the "customers," what shall we serve them? We need to serve them the very grace we have received.

Perhaps you are wondering how you can receive grace in a practical way. For this, we must get into the Word and pray with the Word. To get into the Word is to receive grace, and to pray with the Word is to touch reality. After getting into the Word and praying with the Word, we need to walk in spirit according to the Word. If we do these three things daily, we shall receive a continual supply of grace. With this grace, we shall be enlightened and shall experience the reality of God as grace. This grace spontaneously connects us to the church, giving us a vital link to the "kitchen." In this way we become proper stewards.